Geographic Disparity Report

LIHEAP, CalFresh and food bank assistance across San Diego County zip codes

Analysis period: January–July 2023 (monthly averages)

Summary

- **Need is concentrated in the rural East County and central-southeast San Diego.** Five zip codes form the combined hot spots: Jacumba (91934), Borrego Springs (92004), La Mesa (91941) and San Diego (92114, 92115).
- **Assistance is lowest along the North County coast.** Thirteen zip codes from Carlsbad to Del Mar, Rancho Santa Fe and northern San Diego form a single cold-spot area.
- **Programs rarely conflict, but gaps remain.** No zip code falls in a significant hot spot for one program and a cold spot for another. Ranked individually, however, six zip codes score high on LIHEAP and low on food bank assistance or vice versa, and 21 lack data for at least one program.

Data and Methods

Monthly LIHEAP enrollment, CalFresh issuance and Feeding San Diego distribution were averaged by zip code (January–July 2023) and converted to per-capita rates, excluding zip codes under 500 residents. The combined index averages each zip code's percentile rank (0–100) across programs where at least two report. Clusters use Local Moran's I (Queen contiguity, 999 permutations, $p < 0.05$).

Of 165 zip codes, 110 have a mapped boundary; the rest are PO box zip codes with no area or population. City names were verified against USPS records. CalFresh, LIHEAP and the combined index are clustered countywide (Moran's I = 0.34, 0.21, 0.34); food bank distribution is not (0.06, $p = 0.105$).

Concentrations of Highest Assistance Need

Across all programs, the combined assistance index, analyzed with Local Moran's I ($p < 0.05$), indicated that Jacumba, Borrego Springs, La Mesa and central-southeast San Diego have the highest concentrations of assistance need. The zip codes 91934, 92004, 91941, 92114 and 92115 are the five hot spots: zip codes with high assistance levels surrounded by neighbors that are also high.

Table 1. Hot spots: highest concentration of assistance need (5 zip codes)

Zip Code	City	Combined Index (0–100)	p-value
91934	Jacumba	91.9	0.036
92004	Borrego Springs	80.2	0.025
92115	San Diego	74.2	0.045
92114	San Diego	60.4	0.009
91941	La Mesa	54.9	0.003

Jacumba has no LIHEAP data, so its index is based on CalFresh and food bank only.

Concentrations of Lowest Assistance Need

Across all programs, the combined assistance index, analyzed with Local Moran's I ($p < 0.05$), indicated that the North County coastal communities of Carlsbad, Cardiff by the Sea, Del Mar, Encinitas, Solana Beach and Rancho Santa Fe, together with Escondido and northern San Diego, have the lowest concentrations of assistance need. The zip codes 92007, 92009, 92011, 92014, 92024, 92029, 92067, 92075, 92091, 92127, 92128, 92129 and 92131 fall within this cold-spot area.

Table 2. Cold spots: lowest concentration of assistance need (13 zip codes)

Zip Code	City	Combined Index (0–100)	p-value
92014	Del Mar	6.8	0.017
92009	Carlsbad	7.4	0.032
92091	Rancho Santa Fe	9.3	0.010
92007	Cardiff by the Sea	10.4	0.016
92075	Solana Beach	12.4	0.004
92131	San Diego	19.0	0.036
92128	San Diego	20.9	0.037
92127	San Diego	21.0	0.008
92011	Carlsbad	23.3	0.013
92024	Encinitas	25.8	0.001
92029	Escondido	27.7	0.026
92067	Rancho Santa Fe	30.1	0.001
92129	San Diego	39.6	0.030

Program-Level Patterns

Table 3. Hot spots, cold spots and missing data by program

Program	Hot spots	Cold spots	No data	Moran's I
LIHEAP	4	13	21	0.206 (p = 0.003)
CalFresh	4	21	13	0.341 (p = 0.001)
Food bank	2	7	10	0.064 (p = 0.105)

Overlap. Campo (91906) is the only zip code that is a hot spot for two programs (CalFresh and food bank), while nine zip codes are cold spots for two programs. No zip code is a hot spot for one program and a cold spot for another.

Possible service gaps. Alpine (91901), Pine Valley (91962) and Palomar Mountain (92060) are low outliers on the combined index: they receive little assistance while their neighbors receive a lot.

Energy and Food Assistance Gaps

Each zip code was ranked (0–100) on LIHEAP and food bank assistance and flagged when it fell in the top quarter for one and the bottom quarter for the other. The differential is the leading program's percentile minus the trailing program's.

The zip codes 92119 and 92104 in San Diego and 92067 in Rancho Santa Fe receive high LIHEAP assistance but comparatively little food bank assistance, suggesting they may be underserved for food. The zip codes 91950 in National City, 91901 in Alpine and 92129 in San Diego receive high food bank assistance but comparatively little LIHEAP assistance, suggesting they may be underserved for energy.

Table 4. High LIHEAP, low food bank assistance: potentially underserved for food

Zip Code	City	LIHEAP Percentile	Food Bank Percentile	Differential
92119	San Diego	82.0	10.5	71.5
92067	Rancho Santa Fe	78.7	10.5	68.2
92104	San Diego	83.1	24.0	59.1

Table 5. Low LIHEAP, high food bank assistance: potentially underserved for energy

Zip Code	City	Food Bank Percentile	LIHEAP Percentile	Differential
91950	National City	91.0	21.3	69.7
91901	Alpine	76.0	12.4	63.6
92129	San Diego	78.0	22.5	55.5

Interpreting these gaps. These are potential gaps, not confirmed need. 92119 and 92067 recorded no food bank pounds, likely for lack of a local site, and Rancho Santa Fe's LIHEAP rank rests on few enrollments. Alpine (91901) is the strongest candidate for follow-up.

Data Gaps

Twenty-one zip codes lack data for some programs, mostly military, university and rural ones.

Table 6. Zip codes missing program data

Programs Missing	Zip Codes
All three (9)	91948 Mount Laguna, 92066 Ranchita, 91980 Tecate, 92096 San Marcos; 92134, 92135, 92155, 92161, 92182 San Diego
LIHEAP and CalFresh (4)	92055 Camp Pendleton; 92136, 92140, 92145 San Diego
LIHEAP and food bank (1)	92093 La Jolla
LIHEAP only (7)	91917 Dulzura, 91931 Guatay, 91934 Jacumba, 91962 Pine Valley, 91963 Potrero, 92060 Palomar Mountain, 92091 Rancho Santa Fe

Limitations

- PO box zip codes cannot be mapped (7.1% of CalFresh dollars), and food bank pounds are recorded where food is distributed, not where recipients live.